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Vox Cinemas

Vox Cinema Booking experience: Reducing Friction When Switching Cinemas

At-A-Glance

A self-initiated redesign project exploring how the VOX Cinemas booking experience could be made simpler, clearer, and more intuitive. The project focuses on identifying usability gaps in the existing experience and proposing a more streamlined movie-booking journey.

Team	Role	Timeline
Vijeesh Thattante Valappil (UI/UX)	Mobile application, Website	1-2 Weeks

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Problem Statement

The current VOX booking experience follows a linear, venue-specific journey, making it difficult for users to change cinemas once they have started booking. When users reach the seat-selection stage and find limited availability, there is no clear way to explore or compare another venue without leaving the flow.

This creates a loss-of-context problem: users may have to repeat earlier steps, lose their booking progress, and mentally track information from the previous venue. For a time-sensitive, high-intent task like cinema booking, this adds unnecessary cognitive load and increases the risk of flow abandonment.

How might we let users compare and switch venues at any point before payment, without losing their progress or confidence in the booking?

Constraints and Assumptions

The redesign was approached within the boundaries of VOX Cinemas' existing booking ecosystem. The goal was to improve the venue-selection and switching experience without changing the underlying booking, inventory, pricing, or payment systems.

Showtimes, formats, seat layouts, and pricing vary by cinema.

VIJEESH TV

IMAX, 4DX, GOLD, MAX, and other formats may not be available at every venue.

VIJEESH TV

Users should be able to switch venues before seat selection without significant friction.

VIJEESH TV

Users typically begin the journey with a movie, cinema, date, or showtime rather than following one fixed entry path.

VIJEESH TV

Promo eligibility may change based on venue, showtime, format, or ticket type.

VIJEESH TV

Login/guest state is global booking context rather than venue-specific state.

VIJEESH TV

Users may want to compare multiple cinemas before committing to a showtime, particularly when availability, timing, format, or price differs.

VIJEESH TV

Once seats have been selected and proceed to checkout, switching venues should trigger a clear confirmation because it may release the user's temporary seat hold.

VIJEESH TV

Drop-off rises at seat selection when occupancy is high

VIJEESH TV

Users may select a cinema manually or discover cinemas through location-based recommendations.

VIJEESH TV

Intuitive and Heuristics Analysis

VOX does show the selected venue throughout the booking journey — but it exposes the venue as information, not as an actionable booking control.

The user's mental model

People think in terms of "this movie, around this time, somewhere convenient." Cinema is a flexible detail, and the movie and time are the commitments. The booking flow assumes the opposite, treating venue as fixed once a showtime is clicked.

Current Mental model

Choose cinema → Choose showtime → Enter booking → Choose seats → **Discover poor availability** → Go back / restart

Desired Mental model

Choose cinema → Choose showtime → Enter booking → Choose seats → Discover poor availability → Check other cinemas → **Choose another cinema** → Choose showtime → Select Seat → Continue

Heuristic Analysis

Where	Heuristic	Findings	Severity
Homepage	**H2** Match with real world	Cinema + Movie selectors are prominent, No Major issues	0
What's On	**H3** Flexibility	Option can choose cinema/movie as a primary metrics.	0
Cinemas	**H6** Recognition over recall	One long alphabetical list of cinemas, with no visible sort by distance, time or experience.	2
Showtime	**H1** Visibility of system status	Every showtime pill looks identical, with no hint of seats left or how full the hall is. Users find out only after committing.	3
Showtimes	**H3** User control and freedom	Change Showtime" is the only exit. Users wanting another venue must guess it helps. It also appears before the seat map is usable.	3
Restart	**H7** Efficiency	Login/ Continue as Guest status is lost, when they restart.	4
Summary	**H3** User control and freedom	The bar shows venue, date and time, but no edit control is visible, while Membership and Food & Drinks get a pencil.	2
Payments	**H7** Flexibility	No ticket offers are auto applied while adding the card. Card validation is required which ads an additional step.	1

Design Opportunity

VOX maintains venue visibility throughout the booking journey, but does not provide an equivalent venue-editing mechanism when the user discovers new information at seat selection.When seat availability is poor, let users check other cinemas without leaving the booking context, then revalidate only the information that depends on the selected venue.

Competitive Analysis

The current VOX booking experience follows a linear, venue-specific journey, making it difficult for users to change cinemas once they have started booking. When users reach the seat-selection stage and find limited availability, there is no clear way to explore or compare another venue without leaving the flow.

This creates a loss-of-context problem: users may have to repeat earlier steps, lose their booking progress, and mentally track information from the previous venue. For a time-sensitive, high-intent task like cinema booking, this adds unnecessary cognitive load and increases the risk of flow abandonment.

How might we let users compare and switch venues at any point before payment, without losing their progress or confidence in the booking?

Feature	Vox	Novo	Roxy	Reel	Cinepolis	Bookmyshow*
Cinema first / Movie first discovery	✓ Strong	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Compare same movie across cinemas	✓ Strong	✓ Strong	✓	✓	✓	✓
Availability cue on showtime	✗ Identical	◐	✗	✗	◐	✓ Strong
Cinema/ details remains visible during booking	✓	✓	◐	◐	◐	✓ Strong
Clear booking context	✓ Strong	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓ Strong
Sign-in /Guest flexibility	✓ MAF	✓ FB/Google	✓	✓	✓	✓ Strong
Guest access till seat selection	◐	✗ Poor	✓ Strong	✓	✓	✓
Hold timer visible across the booking	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Venue switching during active booking	✗ Poor	✗	✓ Strong	✗ Poor	✓	✓ Strong
Venue switching from seat selection	✗	✗	✓ Strong	✗	✓	✓
Seat tiers with prices on the map	✗	✓	◐	◐	◐	✓
F&B integrated into journey	✓ Strong	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Guest checkout	✓	◐ Poor	✓ Easy	✓ Easy	✓	✓ Easy
Validating offer	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓ Easy Checkout

✓ Clearly Supported ✗ Not Supported ◐ Partial or less prominent

The competitive review shows that cinema selection and venue comparison are already well-established behaviours across VOX, Novo, Roxy, Reel, Cinépolis, and BookMyShow.

Prioritisation

Now we move from "what is the problem?" to "what should we solve first?"

I listed every idea that addresses a verified finding from Sections 2 and 3, scored it, and sorted it with MoSCoW. You asked for Must-have and Can-have, and I added Should-have as a middle tier because several ideas are valuable but depend on the Musts landing first.

Feature	Impact	Effort	Priority
Availability Cue: Based on seat availability.	Very High	Low	**P0**
Change Cinema : Allow users to go back to previous page during the booking experience.	Very High	Medium	**P0**
Seat tiers with prices on the map.	High	Medium	**P0**
Nearby sorting: allow to sort based on the distance.	Medium	Low	**P1**
Login: Move after the seat map.	Medium	Medium	**P1**
Move the summary to top for easy navigation.	Low	High	**P2**
Resume-booking link for an interrupted flow.	Low	High	**P2**
Change Showtime: Restricted to same Cinema, Give option to view all cinemas.	Low	Low	**P2**

The resulting design scope

In scope

- Cinema switching
- Seat availability cue
- Move login after seat selection
- Sorting by distance
- Seat tier / pricing

Out of scope

- Movie discovery redesign
- Login redesign
- F&B redesign
- Payment redesign
- Loyalty/membership redesign